17 Interview with an NLD legislator from Amyotha Hluttaw on 27 February 2014.
18 On 19 March 2014, when the Hluttaw debated a new electricity scheme, members of the Pyithu Hluttaw Committee on Investment and Industrial Development voted together as a bloc against a rate hike.
19 At the second plenary session of the Amyotha Hluttaw on 1 March 2011, the Speaker U Khin Aung Myint justified the allocation to the membership of legislative committees based on the party ratio, on geography and on the qualifications of the individual legislators.
20 Interview with a Kayin legislator from Pyithu Hluttaw on 1 February 2014.
21 Interview with an RNDP legislator from Rakhine State Hluttaw on 13 March 2014.
22 Based on my discussion with U Sein Tin Win, Speaker of Yangon Region Hluttaw on 4 July 2015, this was also true in state and region legislatures. For instance, the number of complaint letters received by the Yangon Region Hluttaw increased from eighty three in 2011 to almost six hundred in 2013 and 2014.
23 However, there are six possible ways where a speaker can influence the legislature through (i) administrative staff, (ii) allocation of resources and facilities such as staff, office space and equipment, (iii) assembly's schedule, (iv) interpreting procedural rules, (v) plenary session, and (vi) as an active party member (Bach 1999).
24 The Hluttaw rules allow the speaker to choose (i) electronic secret ballot; (ii) paper secret ballot; and (iii) voting by standing up. In addition, voice voting is widely used. Unlike other legislative institutions, Myanmar uses secret ballots. Voice voting is commonly used by the speaker for procedural matters. It is also used when the speaker wants to get it quickly endorsed without any opposition from the floor. Voting by standing up can also be intimidating especially if the speaker is in favour of the other positions to the member's preference. It is usually applied when there is an objection to the voice voting. And unless legislators really oppose a particular decision of the plenary, they would rarely stand up.
25 Interview with U Khin Aung Myint, Speaker of Amyotha Hluttaw on 6 July 2015.
26 See ICG (2009).
27 The constitutional amendment procedure, seating arrangement within the legislature, and fifteen-member legislative committees (each from seven states and regions plus a leader) are all taken from the 1974 Constitution.